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It's One of the Most Beloved Horror Films of the 1980s, but There's One Controversy About It That Will Never Die

This article is part of [Spielberg Week](#), Slate's seven-day celebration of Steven Spielberg.

By the time I spoke to Tobe Hooper in 2000 about the questions surrounding who really directed *Poltergeist*, it quickly became obvious that he was tired of talking about it. It's not hard to see why. *Poltergeist*, the story of a suburban family harassed by vengeful spirits, was the biggest commercial hit of the director's career, but the circumstances surrounding its creation attached an asterisk next to the film's place in his filmography even before the movie arrived in theaters. Asking him to "set the record straight" created the only awkward moment in an otherwise pleasant interview (to the extent that any discussion of films like *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre* can be called "pleasant"). By that point, Hooper had been pestered about it for 18 years. "[I've kind of talked that one to death, really](#)," he replied. "I've been asked that so many times that I feel the record should be straight already."

Yet even now, 44 years after the film's release, the matter of which auteur deserves attribution for *Poltergeist* feels anything but settled, even though Hooper has always been listed as the film's director. In fact, the opening credits couldn't be clearer, at least up to a point. They read, on three successive screens, "Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer Presents," "A Tobe Hooper Film," and "Poltergeist." It's the fourth screen of credits, which appears nearly four minutes later, that starts to complicate the issue, the one reading "A Steven Spielberg Production." So who really deserves credit, and why has this debate endured for nearly half a century?

In 1982, Spielberg was in the process of transforming into a brand. Thanks to *Jaws*, *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*, and *Raiders of the Lost Ark*—a run of massively successful blockbusters interrupted only by the disappointing World War II comedy *1941*—he'd become the most famous director since Alfred Hitchcock, one whose name not only doubled as a mark of quality but suggested a certain type of technically skilled and emotionally resonant filmmaking. It was also, he'd discover, a name that meant something even when associated with films he did not direct.

At the beginning of the 1980s, Spielberg co-founded Amblin Productions with Kathleen Kennedy and Frank Marshall. By the end of that decade, Spielberg's name in the credits, with or without Amblin, would become synonymous with movies that could be described as "Spielbergian"—*The Goonies*, *Gremlins*, *Back to the Future*, *Batteries Not Included*, to name a few—while still retaining the personalities of the directors who made them. But in 1982, that understanding wasn't in place, nor was a sense, or maybe just a consideration, of how heavily Spielberg's name might overshadow all others on a movie poster.

On March 28, 1982, more than a month ahead of *Poltergeist*'s release, MGM ran a two-page ad in the Los Angeles Times featuring an American suburb beneath a dark sky that contained three text paragraphs. The first, filled with dramatic ellipses, touted Spielberg's achievements, stating he had "delighted, mystified, and scared more audiences ... more imaginatively ... than any filmmaker of our time." Hooper goes unmentioned until the second paragraph, which includes him as one name among many, reading:

As producer and co-author of "Poltergeist," Spielberg is joined by co-producer Frank Marshall, with whom he made "Raiders of the Lost Ark," co-authors Michael Grais and Mark Victor, director Tobe Hooper, and the special effects wizardry of Oscar winner Richard

This was unusual. Also unusual: a New York Times profile inspired by the near-simultaneous releases of *Poltergeist* and *E.T. The Extraterrestrial* that [didn't mention Hooper at all](#), and a trailer that describes *Poltergeist* as a film in which “[Steven Spielberg crosses a frightening new threshold into a world within our own](#)” and that features Spielberg’s name in letters [appreciably larger than those used for Hooper’s](#). This last detail prompted Hooper to complain to the Directors Guild of America, which awarded him \$15,000 on the grounds that the trailer “denigrated the role of the director.”

Still, even with Hooper’s outreach to the DGA, all this might be conceivably chalked up to a series of innocent mistakes, the sort of unintentional credit-grabbing Spielberg would learn to avoid with future collaborations, were it not for a Dale Pollock–penned article that appeared in the Los Angeles Times on May 24, 1982 headlined, “[‘Poltergeist’: Whose Film Is It?](#)” Per Hooper, this is where the confusion about the film began. “The genesis of it,” Hooper told me, as he told other interviewers over the years, “came from an article in The L.A. Times”:

When we were shooting the practical location on the house, the first two weeks of filming were exterior, so I had second-unit shots that had to be picked up in the front of the house. I was in the back of the house shooting Robbie [actor Oliver Robins] and the tree, looking down at the burial of the little tweety bird, so Steven was picking those shots up for me. *The L.A. Times* arrived on the set and printed something like, “We don’t know who’s directing the picture.” The moment they got there, Steven was shooting the shot of the little race cars, and from there the damn thing blossomed on its own and started becoming its own legend.

That sounds reasonable, only it’s not what Pollock’s article describes. Instead, Pollock quotes producer Frank Marshall as saying, “The creative force on this movie was Steven. ... Tobe was the director and was on the set every day. But Steven did the design for every story board ... and he was on the set every day except three days when he was in Hawaii with [George] Lucas.” Marshall then goes on to describe a post-production process in which Hooper essentially did not participate, including in supervising the final edit, the mixing, and composer Jerry Goldsmith’s score.

Per Pollock’s article, this seems to have been an extension, and amplification, of the dynamic on the set. JoBeth Williams, who played Diane Freeling, the mother of the central family, describes making the film as “a collaboration with Steven having the final say.” He was also apparently quite hands-on. Years later, Williams would describe Spielberg wading into the water with her for a late-film scene in which Diane finds herself surrounded by skeletons in an unfinished swimming pool, saying, “[If you get electrocuted, it’ll kill me, too.](#)” (What Williams didn’t know, at the time, though Spielberg must have: The film was using real skeletons obtained from a medical supply company.) Zelda Rubinstein, who played the clairvoyant Tangina, was even more frank in a 2007 interview, saying simply, “[I can tell you that Steven directed all six days I was there.](#) I only worked six days on the film and Steven was there. Tobe set up the shots and Steven made the adjustments.” (Though theories about why Spielberg would ghost-direct the movie have varied, citing everything from a noncompete clause in Spielberg’s *E.T.* contract to rumors of a directors’ strike—the former of which

is [reportedly real](#), and the latter of which doesn't make much sense as a motive, as it would equally bar Hooper—Rubinstein's own explanation went out on a limb by suggesting that Hooper was under the influence of "some unacceptable chemical agents.")

Whatever the process—and for every quote from Rubinstein or Marshall, or from [first assistant cameraman John Leonetti](#), or [special effects makeup artist Craig Reardon](#), saying Spielberg directed it in all but name, there are [others](#), including from [most of the other members of the cast](#), that give credit to Hooper—it's impossible not to see Spielberg's influence on the film, from the clutter-filled Freeling home that serves as a companion piece to similar spots in *Close Encounters of the Third Kind* and *E.T.* to the editing rhythms of the film's set pieces. Spielberg's presence is never stronger than the moment the Freeling family watches spirits descend their suburban home's central staircase with the signature look of wordless wonder Kevin B. Lee would dub "[The Spielberg Face](#)" in his video essay of the same name.

Pollock's Los Angeles Times article is accompanied by a photo of Spielberg pointing as he speaks to *Poltergeist* star Craig T. Nelson as Hooper stands beside him, holding a can of Coke. It's easy to conclude that the image pretty much sums up their working relationship and that perhaps *Poltergeist* should be considered a Spielberg film in all but name. Even Spielberg's attempt to settle the issue via an [open letter](#) to Hooper published in the Hollywood Reporter days before the movie's release feels a bit qualified thanks to phrasing like "Through the screenplay you accepted a vision of this very intense movie from the start, and as the director, you delivered the goods." It reads less like high praise than a pat on the head.

It's not that simple, however, and the same Spielberg Face moment also works as groundwork for a counterargument. A creator doesn't have to be Spielberg to draw influence from Spielberg. It's not like Spielberg needed to be present on, say, the set of *Stranger Things* for the many Spielbergian moments found throughout that series' run. And, of course, even if he wasn't standing by his side, Hooper would have to be influenced by Spielberg, an era-defining artist who was already one of the most powerful people in Hollywood in 1982.

What's more, Spielberg was personally invested in the film, having commissioned a screenplay from writers Michael Grais and Mark Victor that [he then rewrote](#). " 'Poltergeist' is what I fear and 'E.T.' is what I love," Spielberg told the New York Times in the paper's Hooper-less profile. "It's me when I was scaring my younger sisters half to death when we were growing up." It only makes sense that the film's elements would bend Spielberg's way. Even Goldsmith's score resembles the work of Spielberg's usual collaborator, John Williams, in ways not evident in the inventive composer's other work.

And yet, for all the scares found in films like *Jaws* and *Jurassic Park*, Spielberg has never made a proper horror film, unless the pre-fame 1972 TV movie *Something Evil* counts. He seems to have needed Hooper to explore that genre with him, if not for him. Though Spielberg gets, and undoubtedly deserves, the film's story credit, Jacob Trussell's [2023 book](#) *Poltergeist* describes a Hooper-Spielberg collaborative process that goes beyond Spielberg handing the director a script and marching orders.

The two first met after a screening of *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre*, and Spielberg later approached Hooper about working on *Night Skies*, the story of aliens menacing a family that Spielberg had conceived as a kind of evil twin to *Close Encounters*. Spielberg had commissioned a *Night Skies* script from John Sayles that he ultimately decided not to make. But he did farm one element of it out to screenwriter Melissa Mathison to develop into its own film: a subplot involving a

friendly extraterrestrial that would become *E.T.* That left the family-under-attack scenario to be recycled. Via conversations with Hooper that included talk of Robert Wise's *The Haunting*, a favorite of both directors, *Night Skies* evolved into the supernatural horror movie *Night Time* and then into *Poltergeist*.

Spielberg had good reason to turn to the Texas-born Hooper for the project. Released in 1974, *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre* is a justly revered horror masterpiece, one rarely equaled in intensity, dread, and just plain ickiness. Hooper's 1976 follow-up, *Eaten Alive*, proved less distinguished, but he'd gotten past that to direct an eerie 1979 miniseries adaptation of Stephen King's *Salem's Lot* and then *The Funhouse*, a thoughtful, offbeat twist on the slasher movie released in 1981. Whatever Spielberg's role in the creation, production, and postproduction of *Poltergeist*, it would doubtlessly have taken a much different form without Hooper's influence—if it was made at all.

Attempting to write Hooper out of *Poltergeist* also does a disservice to the directorial skills evident in Hooper's other work, including his immediate *Poltergeist* follow-ups, a trio of movies made for B-movie specialists the Cannon Group. None match *Poltergeist* or *The Texas Chain Saw Massacre*, but each makes a case for Hooper as a gifted stylist with a puckish sense of humor all his own.

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Released in 1985, *Lifeforce* became instantly infamous as the film with the naked space vampire, and understandably so. As "Space Girl," Mathilda May begins her conquest of Earth in the nude and stays that way for much of the film. But the fact that *Lifeforce*, co-written by Don Jakoby and *Alien*'s Dan O'Bannon, serves as a fun, visually impressive riff on campy '50s sci-fi and the apocalyptic British strain of the same genre, got overlooked amid the giggles. Also largely overlooked: Hooper's 1986 remake of the '50s classic *Invaders From Mars* (adapted from another O'Bannon-Jakoby script), which doubles down on the original's Freudian symbolism with the help of first-rate effects by Stan Winston and John Dykstra. Released the same year, *The Texas Chainsaw Massacre 2* attracted more attention for its graphic violence than the way Hooper and writer L.M. Kit Carson reinvented the original's cannibal family as the ultimate product of the consumerist '80s. "Tobe isn't what you call a take-charge sort of guy," Spielberg told the Los

Angeles Times in the same article Hooper saw as the source of all the confusion about his role in making *Poltergeist*. But these films suggest otherwise. Given a chance to take charge, Hooper produced a string of strange, memorable films that were distinctly his own.

So, to return to the central question: Who directed *Poltergeist*? No thorough accounting suggests that, per the strictest definition of a director's job, anyone but Hooper deserves the credit. But the same accounts also suggest that Spielberg played a part in the making of the film that went well beyond the bounds usually observed by producers and screenwriters. Nonetheless, Spielberg and Hooper would work together again, on both *Amazing Stories* (Hooper directed the series finale) and the Spielberg-produced alien-abduction miniseries *Taken*. Hooper, who [died in 2017 at the age of 74](#), never stopped referring to Spielberg as a friend.

In the end, it seems like the question itself might be flawed. No matter how strong a stamp a director might put on a film—and Spielberg's stamp presses deeper than most directors'—a film is a collaborative process, one born of the contributions of many. Maybe Spielberg hit the mark in his open letter when he referred to the two having a "unique, creative relationship." Maybe it's better to put discussion of who the film belongs to to rest. Regardless of who shaped a given shot or influenced a particular performance, the product speaks for itself. We can wonder what conflict rumbled inside it, or we can simply look at it from the outside, admire the result, and remember that some things are possessed by more than one creative spirit.

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